Introduction

During the first decades of the twenty-first century, popular media portrayed Africa as a dangerous, disorderly continent that was particularly threatening for women. Reflecting such sentiments, Helene Cooper, a Liberian-born journalist for the *New York Times*, called Africa "the worst place there is to be a woman."[1] Writing of the city of Bukavu in the Democratic Republic of Congo, Cooper described "an old woman, in her 30s" walking up a hill away from town:

> She carried so many logs that her chest almost seemed to touch the ground, so stooped was her back. Still, she trudged on, up the hill toward her home. Her husband was walking just in front of her. He carried nothing. Nothing in his hand, nothing on his shoulder, nothing on his back. He kept looking back at her, telling her to hurry up.[2]

Yet Cooper's article communicated not despair, but hope for the women who, in her words, "somehow manage to carry that entire continent on their backs."[3] They were the women who in the Liberian election of 2005 ignored the threats from young men to resume war if their candidate were defeated and flocked to the polls to elect a Harvard-educated banker, Ellen Johnson Sirleaf, as president. With this election, Johnson Sirleaf, imprisoned under

[1] Helene Cooper, "Waiting for Their Moment in the Worst Place on Earth to Be a Woman," *New York Times*, November 16, 2005.
[2] Cooper, "Waiting for Their Moment."
[3] Cooper, "Waiting for Their Moment."

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an earlier regime, became the first woman to be elected head of an African country. These events in another country led Cooper to conclude, "I want to go back to Bukavu to find that woman, and to tell her what happened in Liberia. I want to tell her this. Your time will come too."[4]

Despite the distressing conditions that Cooper depicted, the narrative of oppression oversimplifies the lives of African women by neglecting class, power, and regional and cultural differences among them. In both precolonial and current African societies, women's position was complex, depending on their age and marital status, the economic possibilities open to them, and whether they lived in matrilineal communities where kinship was determined through women or patrilineal societies where it was traced through men.

Cultures also differed in their understanding of female and male differences and similarities. Indeed, the study of African women's history reinforces this complex message, portraying some women as downtrodden and oppressed, yet many also in powerful positions: as queen mothers, wealthy merchants, spiritual leaders, participants in resistance and nationalist movements and revolutionary struggles, and as active modernized professionals in business, law, health care, teaching, arts, and literature. These women include the substantial numbers who hold seats in African parliaments, the three African women who have received the Nobel Peace Prize, and the large number of internationally recognized scholars and writers.

African women's history: historical and cultural contexts

These contrasting images of African women have historical roots in the continent's colonial past, a narrative of white domination that stretched in most places from the mid-nineteenth century into the 1960s and, in parts of southern Africa, from the mid-seventeenth century into the mid 1990s. Strong external influence predated direct European conquest, however. On the west coast, slavery and the slave trade, dating back to the 1490s, already had reshaped political and economic life, ravaging some communities while strengthening others.

[4] Cooper, "Waiting for Their Moment."

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South Africa, colonized by Dutch settlers in the mid-seventeenth century, became a British colony in the early 1800s. Across north Africa and the southern borders of the Sahara and along the east African coast, Western influence was superimposed on Muslim societies, molded respectively by centuries of trade in gold and salt across the desert and maritime commerce across the Indian Ocean. This early period of foreign political, economic, and cultural contact transformed African life in innumerable ways, spreading Islam gradually through a combination of trade, warfare, and intermarriage between Muslim men and local women.

External influence notwithstanding, in both the interior and along the maritime and desert coasts indigenous political, economic, and religious systems were complex and varied, ranging from centralized kingdoms with strong rulers and clear patterns of social hierarchy to smaller-scale communities based around extended families and clans. Societies also differed economically, some depending more heavily on farming, others on herding, and still others on local and long-distance trade. Although most of Africa was rural, towns along the oceans and the "coasts" of the desert fringe developed distinctive patterns of indigenous urban culture, economics, and architecture. In most societies, men were politically and economically dominant, and men with sufficient wealth could marry more than one woman. Virtually everywhere, however, women were granted greater freedom and authority, both in their families and in public life, once they passed their childbearing years.

Although European traders strongly influenced many coastal areas of Africa beginning in the late fifteenth century, only in the nineteenth century did larger numbers of merchants, explorers, and missionaries begin to penetrate the interior in large numbers. In some regions, especially on the west coast and in South Africa, the presence of these outsiders began to create complex changes among small groups of Africans, encouraging them to convert to Christianity, send their children to mission schools, and (in west Africa) to replace traffic in people with the exchange of new commodities such as palm oil and groundnuts. By the mid 1880s, a combination of political and economic conflict within Europe and the tendency of explorers and missionaries from Britain, France, Germany, Portugal, and Italy to become enmeshed in struggles within and among African states and communities led to a "scramble for Africa" among the major European powers.

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European governments staked out their competing claims to the continent at the Berlin Conference in 1884–5. Gradually over the following decades, often through military "pacification" campaigns, these outsiders established control over their new dominions – leaving virtually all of Africa under foreign rule. The exceptions were Ethiopia, whose long-established kings mobilized their military power to stave off occupation, and Liberia, founded by returning slaves from the United States. America's informal influence allowed this west coast country to escape formal colonization.

Twentieth-century transformations

By the early twentieth century, few areas of the continent escaped, even if indirectly, the effects of the new colonial occupation and its aftermath. This book will explore how women experienced, perceived, and influenced the transformations and cultural conflicts of their societies and how they struggled, both individually and collectively, to reshape their lives and communities. It will also examine the apparent paradox in the conflicting images of African women – not only as singularly oppressed and dominated by men, but also as strong, resourceful, and willing to challenge governments and local traditions to protect themselves and their families. I will suggest that women's critical position in society – producing, preparing, and selling food; giving birth to new generations; feeding, educating, and caring for their families; and sustaining traditions of healing and fertility – was precisely the reason that male family members and successive male-dominated governments sought to undermine their economic and political influence and to control their sexuality.

Understanding the tension between women's power and their oppression, between their strength and their vulnerability, offers a new lens for understanding the relationship between the state and society in the twentieth century. Through the transformations of this period – as the colonial state gave way to states controlled by African men, and as the nationalist movements of the 1940s and 1950s yielded to anti-colonial wars and to the democratization movements of the 1990s – women continued to struggle – with increasing success over time – to assert control over their lives and the lives of their families. Yet just as some women were poised to regain or even to surpass the power and

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authority they had lost during the colonial century, both local backlash and global economic forces threatened their achievements in new ways, helping to sustain the conditions and contradictions that Helene Cooper so poignantly described.

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